Parshas Vayeira – The Rule of Three

Introduction: The Power of Three

Parshas Vayeira is one of those unmistakably powerful parshiyos, undeniably rich, emotionally resonant, and full of transformative lessons. Since Torah is hora'ah,a guide for living,this parsha offers a unique chance to learn and grow in the moment.

As we transition from last week's parsha to this one, and look forward to the next, we walk in the footsteps of Avraham Avinu. A fascinating pattern arises,a "rule of three" that surfaces not just here, but across Torah. More often than not, when we encounter a group of three, it's for the good.

This week, we see the three malachim who visit Avraham; the three se'ah of flour that Sarah prepares; and the three-year-old animals brought at the Bris Bein HaBesarim, where there are three types of animals (a cow, a goat, and a ram), three of each, plus additional birds,a pattern of threes within threes. In other cases, we find offerings of three one-year-old animals.

Even in our Shabbos tefillos, we see a triple expression,"ba, bo, bam",appearing in the section about the sanctity of the day, linked to Shacharis, Mincha, and Ma'ariv.

Clearly, three is not just a number. It's a rhythm, a framework, a sacred pattern.

The Unique Three: Akeidas Yitzchak

But one "three" in this parsha stands apart.

When Hashem tells Avraham to bring his son to the Akeidah, the command includes a trio of emotionally charged terms:

"Take now your son, your only one, the one you love,Yitzchak."
(קח נא את בנך את יחידך אשר אהבת את יצחק" (בראשית כב:ב"

This pasuk is so foundational, it appears in our daily tefillos.

Rashi explains that Hashem was speaking with kindness, gently preparing Avraham for the unimaginable: offering his own son, the one through whom the entire Jewish future was meant to unfold.

But the Sfas Emes opens a deeper perspective: Each of these phrases represents another level of mesirus nefesh,self-sacrifice.

- **Bincha** – Your son. A basic connection. Possibly one of many.

- **Yechidcha** – Your only one. Singular, exclusive, irreplaceable.
- **Asher ahavta** – The one you love. An emotional, deeply personal bond.

Each phrase ascends in intensity. Each step raises the cost,and the spiritual reward,of sacrifice.

What's the Message for Us?

Had Hashem said simply, "Take Yitzchak," Avraham would have complied without question. He lived as a merkavah, a pure vehicle of the Divine Will.

So why include so many extra words?

Because Torah teaches for eternity. The Midrashim and Mefarshim reveal that this wasn't only for Avraham,it was for us. For future generations who would need to develop their own capacities for giving, for sacrifice, for climbing spiritual levels.

Sometimes we give up something minor. Sometimes it's significant. Sometimes it's something we deeply love. That's the process of spiritual growth.

Mesirus Nefesh and the Three Cardinal Sins

This triad also mirrors the **three cardinal sins**,the aveiros for which a Jew must give up their life rather than transgress:

- **Avodah Zarah** – Idolatry
- **Giluy Arayos** – Forbidden sexual relationships
- **Shefichas Damim** – Murder

The source for this is found in Gemara Sanhedrin 74a:

"Rav Yehuda said in the name of Rav: From where do we know that one must give up their life rather than commit idolatry, forbidden relations, or murder? Because it says: 'And you shall love Hashem your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might' (Devarim 6:5),even if He takes your soul."

אמר רב יהודה אמר רב: מנין לעבודה זרה וגילוי עריות ושפיכות דמים שייהרג ואל יעבור?
שנאמר: "ואהבת את ה' אלקיך בכל לבבך ובכל נפשך ובכל מאדך" (דברים ו:ה) –
אפילו נוטל את נפשך .

Now, look again at the three phrases:

- **Bincha** – A child. In holiness, a child is the result of a mitzvah. But from giluy arayos, the result is distorted. According to some opinions, a mamzer's atonement only comes through generational suffering or fire at the end of days.

- **Yechidcha** – The only one. The concept of "only one" links to the Oneness of Hashem. Idolatry is its opposite. Letting go of our personal "yechid" for Hashem is a form of devotion that counteracts Avodah Zarah.

- **Asher ahavta** – Love. Love can inspire the highest good or lead to the worst crimes of passion. Torah love uplifts. Unchecked love can lead to jealousy and, tragically, murder.

Each phrase aligns with one sin,and each also offers its tikkun. Through Avraham's layered mesirus nefesh, we learn how to cleanse, uplift, and live with purpose.

A Pattern That Extends Throughout Torah

Avraham didn't just pass a test. He mapped a blueprint for generations.

This pattern of three continues:

- The Akeidah occurred on the third day.

- We celebrate Shalosh Regalim.

- We descend from the three Avos: Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov.

- Even the word Av (father) equals three in gematria.

When a father acts with righteousness and love, and the children reflect that back, a third entity emerges, the Shechinah, resting between them. It's a Divine triangle.

Closing Reflection

Our Avos gave us a gift: a way to live with spiritual awareness, personal integrity, and deep connection to Hashem. It's our turn to take that gift seriously.

So I stop and ask myself:

- What have I given up out of love for Hashem?

- What have I surrendered that is uniquely mine?

- What small comforts or habits have I sacrificed for a higher purpose?

And most importantly: What is it within me, what spark of inherent worth, what inner strength or soul-rooted depth, makes me even capable of offering things up for Hashem and those around me? What gives me the merit to be counted among those who live a life of such avodah? Where does that quiet, sacred courage come from, and how do I continue to honor it?

Because I love my **Av**,
And I love **Hashem**.

Have a wonderful, wonderful Shabbos.